

Murdoch came in, doubled the fee and, in Charlotte's telling, helped transform the economics of sports broadcasting. "Ever since then," she says, "the value of the media rights has escalated."

Then there was the battle over the Cowboys' own star logo.

"When we came in, we did not own our logo," Charlotte says. "So, we couldn't go take the star and put it on a T-shirt and sell it. No team did. The league controlled it all."

The Cowboys pushed back, arguing that if they had bought the team, they had bought the star too. "We should control our own logo," Charlotte says. They struck a deal with Nike and turned up on the sideline in its apparel, prompting fury at league headquarters.

"The league office went nuts," she says. "They were like, 'You can't do that. We have Reebok. You can't put Nike down there.'" The NFL sued the Cowboys for \$400 million; Dallas responded with a \$700 million countersuit. "At the 11th hour, the league settled, and it gave every NFL team the right to have their own logo," Charlotte says.

Once clubs could truly own and monetise their own identity, new streams of local sponsorship, merchandising and brand extensions opened up across the league. The same instinct shaped how the Cowboys thought about their stadium. In the old model, Charlotte says, venues were largely a financial burden. Expensive to maintain, active only on matchday and dormant the rest of the year. With the Cowboys playing only a handful of home games, that model made little sense.

"Back then, most stadiums were just a financial hole," Charlotte says. "You just kept pouring money in it. It didn't generate any kind of income to sustain itself, just to turn the lights on."

"We're only there ten days. So, the rest of the year, you had to find a way to have it be a business model.

The shift touched everything from concessions, events, rentals and the way the building could be used on the 355 days when the Cowboys



were not playing inside it. "From how we did the concessions, to how we did other events that would come into the building and rent the space, to do a concert, all of that," Charlotte says.

"And then when we built AT&T Stadium, it was the first time anyone had come in and put — we have over 370 suites, we have all of these club seats — we changed the dynamic that had been in the league in the past and created a completely new financial model around that."

The point was not simply to host football games, but to ensure the venue was alive all year. "We still sell stadium tours, and we have a million people come out just when nothing's going on, just to come take a look at it," Charlotte says. "So, it's actually making money every week. It's making money every day."

In recent years, the AT&T Stadium has hosted sold-out concerts by Ed Sheeran, Beyonce, Billy Joel & Stevie Nicks and Taylor Swift.

But Charlotte insists the building was never conceived purely as a revenue engine. "We could have built our stadium for \$700 million," she says. "Instead, we put \$1.2 billion into it, and it was all for the fans. It was all for the wow factor, so they would walk in and go, 'Oh my gosh, they did this for me.'"

All ears: Charlotte Jones in conversation with Ayon Sengupta, editor of *Sportstar*. VLADIMIR MEYMAN

In Charlotte's mind, that emotional reaction mattered as much as the balance sheet. The stadium had to tell fans, before a ball was even kicked, that the organisation had invested in their experience.

For all the grandeur, Charlotte insists the fan experience begins with less glamorous questions. "The basic things are important," she says. "Is it easy to get in and out? How long does it take me to get in and how long does it take me to get out?" The venue had to feel vast without becoming exhausting, one of the many things Indian stadiums can learn from the Cowboys about fan experience.

That thinking extended even to the stadium's most extravagant feature, its giant video board. Charlotte says it was never intended simply as a symbol of excess, but as a way of democratising the experience inside a vast building.

"Those are for those people, the people in the cheapest seats. They need the best view," she says. The idea was that even the fan furthest from the field should still be able to